Xinghao Yao

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Research Fields

Primary: Behavioural Economics; AI Economics.
Secondary: Experimental Economics; Information Economics; Auctions and Market Design.

References

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Education

The University of Queensland **2023-present**
PhD in Economics (expected early 2027)
Supervisors: Kenan Kalayci and Lionel Page.

The University of Queensland **2022**
Master of Advanced Economics

The University of Queensland **2018-2021**
Master of Applied Econometrics

Job Market Paper

How Robust Is LLM Economic Decision-Making? An Auction Benchmark
with Kenan Kalayci

We examine the robustness of economic decision-making by large language models (LLMs) using a theory-grounded benchmark of 78 auction environments spanning bidding, participation, and information purchase. Our findings reveal substantial variation in decision accuracy across auction environments and demonstrate that performance in one decision type does not necessarily generalize to others. This dependence on the decision environment extends to how LLMs respond to additional information that leaves theoretical predictions unchanged. It also qualifies the benefits of reasoning: enabling reasoning improves overall performance in the tested comparisons, but its gains remain uneven across tasks. These results support evaluating LLMs for decision-making against the conditions and connected decisions relevant to their intended use, rather than inferring general competence from isolated successes or aggregate scores.

Working Papers

Information Disclosure in Private-Value Auctions
with Kenan Kalayci | *Working paper*

Working Papers

What You See Is All There Is? A Registered Direct Replication of Enke (2020)
R&R | Journal of the Economic Science Association

This paper reports a registered direct replication of Enke (2020) in a different language, laboratory and software implementation. Participants estimate the mean of a full set of signals after observing a selected subset. Those who must infer the implications of hidden signals place excessive weight on the mean of visible signals compared with participants given an explicit summary of the hidden information. The replication supports the main finding, but provides only limited support for the proposed mechanism that unobserved information is neglected because it fails to come to mind. Greater computational complexity increases such neglect.

Sponsorship Disclosure as a Strategic Informational Cue: A Two-Sided Labelling Model and Meta-Analysis of Influencer Marketing
with Tianyuan Feng | *Major revision | Journal of the Academy of Marketing Science (FT50)*

This paper integrates a two-sided labelling model with a three-level meta-analysis of 63 articles, 89 studies and 258 effect sizes. It studies how sponsorship disclosure affects consumer responses and how these effects vary across products, influencers and audiences. The evidence points to persuasion knowledge as a central mechanism behind the negative average effect of disclosure on consumer responses, relative to no disclosure. My contribution was to develop the paper's two-sided labelling model.

From Analysis to Affect: Modeling and Measuring Finfluencer Communication with Generative LLMs
with Tianyuan Feng | *Under review | Journal of the Academy of Marketing Science (FT50)*

The same investment view can be presented through analytical reasoning or emotional expression. We examine how the former shapes finfluencers' perceived competence and why analysis matters when emotion draws more engagement. Using a codebook-guided large language model, we classify 47,707 posts from 396 finfluencers on X. Emotional expression is associated with more likes and replies than analytical content, with a stronger advantage for emotion-dominant posts by widely followed creators. Our model explains why analysis can remain valuable despite this disadvantage: the reputation it builds supports engagement with both formats. Two preregistered experiments reproduce emotion's advantage in liking intentions, strengthened by a higher displayed follower count, while showing that analysis increases perceived competence. Mediation analyses link this competence benefit to following and subscription intentions. Together, the model and evidence suggest that analysis can contribute to an engagement-oriented strategy by signaling competence and supporting interest in future content.

My contribution comprises the economic modelling and generative LLM-based textual analysis, including the classification of semantic content and discrete emotion frames.

Work in Progress

Accuracy or Affirmation? Competition in AI Advice Markets

Underquoting in Endogenous Entry Auctions

Do you know how attractive you are? A Two-Sided Search Model with Self-Uncertainty

Research Collaboration	**Project Silicon** Contribute experimental data and replication materials, and review simulation results based on our experiments.	
Teaching Experience	**Tutor, The University of Queensland** Microeconomic Analysis: student evaluation 4.93/5. Introduction to Econometrics: student evaluation 4.8/5.	**2023-2026**
Conferences	Asia-Pacific ESA Meeting, University of Melbourne | Presenter	2026
	Australasian Economic Theory Workshop (AETW), Auckland | Presenter	2026
	Australian PhD Conference in Economics and Business, UNSW | Presenter	2025
	Summer School in Experimental and Behavioral Economics, University of Crete | Participant	2025
	Foundations of Utility and Risk (FUR), The University of Queensland | Presenter	2024
Other Related Experience	Research Assistant, UQ QSMAT program.	
	Summer Research Scholar, The University of Queensland	2019-2020
	Master's thesis: constructed a Chinese financial-text corpus incorporating domain-specific expressions for sentiment classification and predicting the direction of stock price movements.	
	DiDi, Safety Department: behavioural analysis	Jun-Nov 2017
Research Skills and Languages	Methods: laboratory experiments, applied econometrics, game-theoretic modelling, machine learning and natural language processing.	
	Software: Python (proficient); Stata, R and MATLAB (working knowledge); oTree.	
	Languages: Mandarin (native); English (fluent).	